

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Generator safety

HOME BUILDING / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Operate a portable generator outdoors at least 20 feet from doors, windows and vents, with exhaust directed away from buildings. Never run it in a home, garage or enclosed space. Use working CO alarms and never connect a generator to a wall outlet.

Do now.

**Choose outdoor placement**

01

Keep the generator away from occupied buildings and openings, including neighbors.

**Connect safely**

02

Use rated cords as instructed; a building connection requires a professionally installed transfer switch.

**Refuel safely**

03

Shut down and let it cool before refueling. Store fuel safely outside living areas.

**Check CO alarms**

04

If an alarm sounds or symptoms occur, leave for fresh air and call emergency services.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

If there is no safe outdoor position, do not run the generator. Use battery lights and ration stored electrical power for medical needs and communications. Do not improvise a connection to household wiring or operate it indoors because the weather is bad.

Watch for.

An open garage door does not make indoor generator operation safe.

People & practical needs.

Keep children and pets away from the running equipment and fuel. Check working carbon-monoxide alarms near sleeping areas. One adult should control refueling and keep fuel storage separate from occupied rooms and escape routes.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Read the manufacturer instructions before a crisis. Plan weather protection that does not enclose the generator or obstruct exhaust.

Check the next usable option

Read the manufacturer instructions before a crisis. Plan weather protection that does not enclose the generator or obstruct exhaust.

When the first option is unavailable

If there is no safe outdoor position, do not run the generator. Use battery lights and ration stored electrical power for medical needs and communications. Do not improvise a connection to household wiring or operate it indoors because the weather is bad.

Questions in the field.

Where is the exhaust going?

Check the generator's position relative to every nearby opening, not just your own back door. Outdoor exhaust can enter neighboring buildings. Keep the required separation and point exhaust away; a garage with its door open is still an unsafe location.

Can I connect it to a household outlet?

Never feed power into a wall outlet. Backfeeding can endanger utility workers and others. Household circuit connections need appropriate installed transfer equipment and qualified electrical work. Use equipment and cords according to the actual manufacturer's instructions.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Generator safety · official guidance

<https://www.cdc.gov/carbon-monoxide/factsheets/generator-safety-fact-sheet.html>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/generator-safety/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.